You have no doubt heard the disastrous intelligence of the massacre of our army at Canbool; the Shah has behaved very well about the affairs of Afghanistan, he has had repeated messages from Herat offering to give up the place to him, to all of which he has refused to listen. If he were to make a movement to the Eastward it would materially increase our difficulties in Afghanistan, by giving encouragement to the Afghans who are opposing us.

The Russians have sent some ships and troops to occupy a small island or islands on the south eastern shore of the Caspian, near Astrabad. The way this has been effected is rather curious and characteristic of the Russian proceedings in the East. You perhaps have heard that for the last century the Turcomans or Tartar tribes who inhabit the great desert to the East of the Caspian have been in the habit of making incursions into Persia and carrying off the inhabitants into slavery and selling them in Khiva, Bokhara and other Tartar states. These inroads were at their height during the latter part of Fatteh Alee Shah's reign, but by this Shah's vigorous measures in Khorasan had been a good deal repressed. Still however they are always going on, chiefly over the frontier from the Caspian Sea towards Herat; and one of their roads was coasting in large boats by Astrabad along the shores of the Caspian to plunder in the province of Mazenderan. Some time ago the Prime minister (the Hadji as he is called) was complaining of these inroads and piracies and said in the course of conversation with one of the attachés of the Russian Mission that he wished that there were some Russian forces there to stop them. No more was said upon the subject until some months afterwards when one of the Russian Mission came to the Hadji and said "I have brought you good news" "What is it?" said the Hadji. "Our army has arrived off Astrabad." The Hadji was quite taken aback and had very little to say for himself. The Russians now demand, permanently to occupy one of the islands in these seas, as they say to repress the piracies which have been committed by the Turcoman boats on their ships, which trade to the coasts of Mazenderan (pt of anct Hyrcania). If the Russians succeed in forming a military settlement here, I shall think it most probable that we shall deem ourselves obliged to retake and maintain Herat. This will bring us, to within about thirty marches of one another. And a practicable road for armies between us.

By Mr Bonham, I sent home, to be delivered to my Mother, to send to you, a silver handled dagger or rather knife. It formerly belonged to the Governor of the town and you may think it curious as shewing the sort of thing Persians of rank wear stuck on their shawl girdles: It did not cost me much I think I paid the value of 25/ for it, so do not suppose I am sending you an expensive present. I have had it by me some time but had no good opportunity of sending it. It is not likely to be of much use to you unless some of your neighbours

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